

Q The range of strollers and carriages is incredible. How on earth do we choose?

When thinking about what to buy, the best starting point is to focus on your specific needs: what will suit your lifestyle, your budget, and work well for both your baby and you and your partner.

If you use public transportation often or travel up and down steps regularly, you may find that a lightweight, easily foldable stroller, or a more compact carriage, meets your needs well. If you drive regularly, consider a travel system where you can alternate a chair or car seat on a base, making it easy to move your baby from home to car to stroller without disturbing him too much. Sturdy models with swivel wheels are easy to maneuver and great for walking in cities and towns; if you walk on rough terrain, a fixed wheel is best, making it easier to push the carriage over uneven ground.

Comfort is key

Your baby will spend an extraordinary amount of time in his stroller or travel system. Some carriages have adjustable seats that start off fully reclined and can be adjusted into a more upright mode as your baby grows. Check that the stroller is well padded and has a sturdy back support, and decide whether you want your baby to face inward toward you, or outward. Some models have a reversible seat so you can keep an eye on and make eye contact with your newborn, and turn the seat out when your baby is older. Double check that the handle is high enough for you so you don't have to lean over and strain your back. If you and your partner are significantly different heights, you may want to choose a model with an adjustable handle.

Make sure you try out the model in the store before you purchase and practice using it before the birth.

HOW TO DETERMINE WHICH TRAVEL SYSTEM IS RIGHT FOR YOUR FAMILY

The following summary looks at the range of options, explaining key features and highlighting the pros and cons of different models.

RANGE	DESCRIPTION
Convertables 	These allow your newborn to lie flat and are more traditional looking than strollers. Your baby has an enclosed, cosy environment, and can see you as you push him along. Later, these can convert to accommodate a seated baby.
Carriages 	These allow your newborn to lie flat and are more traditional looking than strollers. Your baby has an enclosed, cosy environment, and can see you as you push him along. Models with detachable carrying cribs double as travel cribs for the first few months.
Travel systems 	Stroller frames that can snap on your baby's infant car seat are suitable from birth and are easiest for you to bring your baby anywhere you go—for a walk, for a drive—without needing to rouse or disturb him when it's time to put on a seat belt. This option likely won't last through your baby's first year; he's likely to outgrow the car seat when he's 9 to 12 months, depending on his size and the manufacturer's requirements.
Strollers 	Strollers are lightweight and easy to use and usually fit easily into a car trunk, so are great for travel and shopping. While some strollers are only for older, sitting babies, some models recline fully to accommodate newborns. Strollers can't be used as part of a travel system with car seats or as a carry crib.
Double strollers 	If you have twins or a toddler who needs to be pushed around with your newborn, you will need a double stroller. These can be side-by-side or tandem strollers, where one seat is positioned behind or under the main seat. Side-by-side strollers allow your babies to see each other and have an unobstructed view. Tandem strollers mean that one child has a restricted view and can be difficult to manage on steps, but can be easier to get through tight spaces such as doors. You can also buy single stroller models that can be upgraded into a double stroller when required.